



P48 · 30 PAGES, PRINTABLE + FILLABLE

Adoption Wait + Welcome Pack

A thirty-page planner for adoptive parents. The long wait of home study and matching, the financial planning, the grief that often precedes or accompanies adoption, the match call, the welcome day, the first week with the child. Birth-family relationships honored throughout. Includes a "how we will talk about our family" page using language adoption advocates and adult adoptees recommend.

Soothemade *Notes*

A SMALL APOTHECARY OF PRINTABLES · MADE SLOWLY

A note before you start

You are becoming a parent. The route is one most planners do not cover.

Maybe you are in the early months of the home study. Maybe you have been waiting for a match for a long time, and the wait is starting to feel longer than what people understand. Maybe you got a call that this could be the one, and now you are reading this in a hurry. Maybe a child is arriving in your house this week with a duffel bag and a social worker.

This planner is for that route. It is not a manual on how to adopt. The agency, the lawyer, the social worker do that. This is the planning surface.

The brand voice in this planner respects the complexity. There is grief in many adoption journeys, sometimes from infertility, sometimes from prior loss, sometimes from the birth family's loss that is the necessary other half of every adoption. There is also joy. The planner holds both.

Soothemade

This is a planning tool, not legal or social-work advice. Your agency, attorney, and social worker are the right resources for the procedural and clinical aspects of your adoption. The crisis-line page is at the back. Infertility, prior loss, and birth-family grief are real parts of many adoption journeys. perinatal mental-health care applies to adoptive parents too.

How to use this planner

- The planner is not chronological. You can use it in any order.
- The “how we will talk about our family” page is worth reading early. The language you use now will set the tone for the long term.
- The grief page is optional. If your path did not include infertility or prior loss, skip it. If it did, the page is here.
- The match-call page is brief on purpose. The call, if and when it happens, is mostly fast.

This is its own pregnancy

A page to come back to.

A REMINDER

You are pregnant in a different sense.

You are growing the parts of yourself that will hold a child. You are making decisions about how you will parent, about what your family will look like, about how money flows, about how the room will be set up. You are reading books. You are practicing the things you will do. You are scared. You are excited. You are tired of being asked when the baby is coming.

Friends will assume you are not "really" pregnant because there is no visible bump. Some will forget you are in this process at all. Others will treat the wait as if it is shorter than it is.

This planner is one of the things naming the truth: you are preparing for a child. That preparation is its own season. It deserves the same respect any pregnancy gets.

WHAT I WANT TO REMEMBER ABOUT THIS SEASON, NOW, BEFORE THE CHILD ARRIVES

Home study prep

The home study is the foundational paperwork pull. Depending on your country and type of adoption, the specifics vary widely. This is a generic prep checklist.

WHAT THE HOME STUDY USUALLY ASKS FOR

- ☐ Birth certificates for each adult in the household
- ☐ Marriage certificate (if applicable)
- ☐ Divorce decrees (if applicable)
- ☐ Driver's license / state ID
- ☐ Social Security cards
- ☐ Tax returns (typically the last 3 years)
- ☐ Financial documents (bank statements, asset list, debt list)
- ☐ Medical history (your provider often fills out a form)
- ☐ Mental health history
- ☐ Drug / alcohol history
- ☐ Criminal background check (fingerprinting required)
- ☐ Child abuse clearance
- ☐ References (typically 3-5, not family)
- ☐ Employer verification
- ☐ Insurance documentation (health, life, home)
- ☐ Pet vaccination records
- ☐ Home safety inspection (smoke alarms, water heater temp, babyproofing where applicable)
- ☐ Photos of the home
- ☐ Autobiographical statements (each adult writes a personal essay, often more than once during the process)
- ☐ Interviews (each adult, separately and together)

WHAT WE HAVE GATHERED SO FAR

WHAT WE STILL NEED

OUR SOCIAL WORKER

Name: _____
Agency: _____
Phone: _____
Email: _____

OUR HOME-STUDY VISIT DATES

First visit: _____

Follow-up visits: _____

WHAT I LEARNED ABOUT MYSELF FROM WRITING THE AUTOBIOGRAPHICAL ESSAY

Agency, lawyer, consultant tracker

Adoption has many possible professional partners. Track who is doing what.

TYPE OF ADOPTION WE ARE PURSUING (circle / write):

- ☐ Domestic infant (private agency)
- ☐ Domestic infant (attorney-only)
- ☐ Foster-to-adopt (through state/county)
- ☐ International
- ☐ Kinship / family
- ☐ Other: _____

PRIMARY PROFESSIONAL CONTACTS

ADOPTION AGENCY

Name: _____
Caseworker: _____
Phone: _____
Email: _____

ADOPTION ATTORNEY (if using)

Name: _____
Phone: _____
Email: _____

ADOPTION CONSULTANT (if using)

Name: _____
Phone: _____

SOCIAL WORKER (home study, post-placement)

Name: _____
Phone: _____

POST-ADOPTION COUNSELING / SUPPORT

Therapist or group: _____
Phone: _____

OTHER RESOURCES

- ☐ Adoption-competent therapist (consider this in advance)
- ☐ Pediatrician who knows about adoption-specific issues
- ☐ Local adoptive-family support group
- ☐ Online community (specific to type of adoption)

Financial planning

Adoption is expensive. The costs vary enormously by type (foster-to-adopt is often free or close to it. international or domestic infant private adoption can be \$30k-\$60k+). Tax credits exist in many countries. Grants exist. Loans exist.

THE COST ESTIMATE FROM OUR AGENCY / ATTORNEY

Agency or attorney fee: \$____
Home study: \$____
Birth-mother expenses (if domestic): \$____
Legal fees: \$____
Travel (if applicable): \$____
Post-placement supervision: \$____
Other: \$____

TOTAL ESTIMATED: \$____

OUR FUNDING PLAN

Savings: \$____
Family loan / gift: \$____
Employer adoption benefit: \$____
Adoption tax credit (US: refundable): \$____
(Check current year's amount with your tax professional)
Adoption grants (apply early): \$____
Adoption loan: \$____
Other: \$____

GRANTS WE HAVE APPLIED TO

EMPLOYER BENEFITS

Adoption benefit: \$____
Parental leave (does it apply to adoption?):

TAX PREP

Our tax accountant: _____
Adoption-specific knowledge: ☐ yes ☐ confirm

A REMINDER: KEEP EVERY RECEIPT FROM THE BEGINNING. AGENCY FEES, LEGAL FEES, TRAVEL, MEDICAL EXPENSES FOR THE BIRTH MOTHER, BACKGROUND

CHECKS, EVEN THE FINGERPRINTING FEES. THE ADOPTION TAX CREDIT IS SIGNIFICANT IN MANY COUNTRIES AND APPLIES TO QUALIFIED EXPENSES.

The grief page

Optional. For the adoption paths that included a previous loss.

Many adoptive parents arrive at adoption after infertility. Others after pregnancy loss. Others after a failed match. Others after years of trying that did not work.

THE LOSS BEFORE THIS HOPE

What I want to acknowledge about the path that got me here:

The thing I gave up to get to this point:

What I am still grieving, even as I am also hopeful:

A NOTE: ADOPTION IS NOT A CONSOLATION PRIZE. IT IS A LEGITIMATE PATH. BUT IT IS ALSO NOT THE END OF THE GRIEF YOU MAY HAVE BEEN CARRYING. THE GRIEF CAN COEXIST WITH THE EXCITEMENT. NEITHER NEGATES THE OTHER.

What I want my future child to know about how we got to them:

(You do not have to write the full story now. This is just a seed for the conversation you will have one day.)

PERINATAL MENTAL HEALTH IS ALSO FOR YOU

The hormonal piece is different from biological pregnancy. The emotional piece is not. The wait, the grief, the anticipation, all of it is real. Adoption-competent therapists exist. So do adoptive-parent support groups.

The provider or therapist I am reserving the number for:

The wait, emotional check-ins

The wait does not have a known end. Some wait weeks. Some wait years. Some have a near-match and then a fall-through.

MONTH 1 OF THE WAIT DATE: _____

What I am holding right now:

What is keeping me anchored:

MONTH 3 DATE: _____

What has shifted in three months:

What has gotten harder:

MONTH 6 DATE: _____

The thing I have learned about myself in this stretch:

MONTH 9 DATE: _____

What is sustaining me:

MONTH 12 DATE: _____

One year of waiting. The thing I would tell month-1 me:

BEYOND 12 MONTHS DATE: _____

A REMINDER: THE WAIT IS NOT A FAILURE TO PERFORM. IT IS NOT A REFLECTION OF YOUR FITNESS AS A PARENT. IT IS THE NATURE OF ADOPTION. THE TIMING IS LARGELY OUTSIDE OF YOUR CONTROL.

When a match falls through

Some adoption matches do not become placements. The birth parent changes their mind. The legal process derails. The match was not the right one. Some adoptive families experience this multiple times.

This page is for that.

WHAT JUST HAPPENED, IN MY OWN WORDS

WHAT I FEEL RIGHT NOW

WHAT I HAVE TOLD MY AGENCY / ATTORNEY

WHO ELSE I HAVE TOLD

WHAT I AM NOT TELLING ANYONE YET

THE THING I WANT THE PEOPLE WHO LOVE ME TO UNDERSTAND, RIGHT NOW

A REMINDER: A FAILED MATCH IS A REAL LOSS. NOT A "MAYBE" LOSS. A REAL ONE. THE PEOPLE WHO COMPARE IT TO "JUST A DELAY" OR "JUST A DISAPPOINTMENT" ARE NOT PEOPLE WHO HAVE BEEN HERE.

THE GRIEF IS ALLOWED. WE WILL NOT TELL YOU IT HAPPENED FOR A REASON. WE WILL NOT TELL YOU THE NEXT MATCH IS THE RIGHT ONE.

WE WILL TELL YOU THIS LOSS DESERVES THE TIME IT NEEDS.

A note on respect for the birth family: even when a match falls through because the birth parent chose to parent, that is the birth family's right and a legitimate choice. The adoption community has language for this: "we wish them well" rather than "they backed out." Holding that respect, even in grief, is part of the work.

The match call

When the call comes, whatever month or year, things move fast.

THE CALL DETAILS

Date the call came: _____

Time: _____

Who called: _____

WHAT THEY TOLD US

Child's age / due date: _____

Birth family situation, in their words:

Where the child is now: _____

When the placement could happen: _____

What we need to decide by: _____

WHAT THEY ASKED US

WHAT WE NEED TO ASK BEFORE COMMITTING

- ☐ What information do we have about the birth family?
- ☐ What information do we have about the child's medical history?
- ☐ Has the birth family / mother had counseling about this decision?
- ☐ Is the legal pathway clear in this state / country?
- ☐ What is the post-placement supervision plan?
- ☐ What is the birth family's preferred level of openness?
- ☐ What is the estimated total cost from here?
- ☐ How quickly do we need to move?

WHAT WE DECIDED, AND WHEN

Decision: _____

Date decided: _____

How we feel:

The welcome-day plan

The day they arrive in your home, however that arrival happens.

WHEN THE DAY IS LIKELY

Estimated date: _____

WHO IS THERE

Adults in the home: _____

Other kids: _____

Any extended family invited (often best to be minimal at first):

WHAT WE HAVE READY

- ☐ Crib / bed / sleep space, set up
- ☐ Car seat installed (if infant)
- ☐ Diapers + wipes (if young)
- ☐ Clothing in age-appropriate sizes (often unknown until arrival)
- ☐ Comfort items
- ☐ Food / formula if applicable
- ☐ A pediatrician selected
- ☐ An appointment scheduled within the first week
- ☐ The legal paperwork sorted (often a lot of it at this stage)
- ☐ Phone fully charged
- ☐ Camera or phone for photos

WHAT THE FIRST FEW HOURS WILL LOOK LIKE

Bringing them in: _____

First meal / feed: _____

First nap: _____

First night in their new room: _____

A NOTE FOR INFANT PLACEMENTS

If the child is coming from a hospital or a temporary placement, they may be processing a lot. Calm voices, low light, a slow first day. Skip the photo extravaganza. The big visit can happen next week.

A NOTE FOR OLDER CHILDREN

The child you are welcoming has a history. They may have had other homes. They may have favorite foods you do not know about yet. They may be tested for safety in the way new children of any age test new homes.

Ask the social worker:

- What does this child know about coming to live with us?
- What food do they like?
- What is their bedtime routine?
- What are their fears?
- What words do they use for the bathroom / for upset / for hungry?
- What is their relationship to their previous caregivers?
- What do we say if they ask hard questions in the first week?

WHO IS DOING WHAT THE FIRST DAY

WHAT WE PROMISE EACH OTHER, AS THE ADULTS, BEFORE THEY ARRIVE

The first week

DAY 1 DATE: _____

How they slept: _____

How they ate: _____

The hardest moment:

The best moment:

DAY 2 DATE: _____

Notes:

DAY 3 DATE: _____

Notes:

DAY 4 DATE: _____

Notes:

DAY 5 DATE: _____

Notes:

DAY 6 DATE: _____

Notes:

DAY 7 DATE: _____

ONE-WEEK NOTE

What is true now that was not true seven days ago:

What I am still figuring out:

What I am proudest of, this week:

Birth-family communication

If your adoption is open or semi-open, communication with the birth family is part of the long-term picture. The frequency, the form, and the boundaries depend on what was agreed.

OUR AGREEMENT, AS WE UNDERSTAND IT

Form (letters, photos, calls, visits, all of the above):

Frequency:

Through the agency / direct:

WHAT WE WILL SEND, IN THE FIRST YEAR

- ☐ A welcome letter at placement
- ☐ Photos at each milestone (birth-family preference noted)
- ☐ A note on holidays
- ☐ Annual update letter

WHAT WE WANT TO SAY IN THE FIRST LETTER

A NOTE: THE FIRST LETTER IS HARD. KEEP IT SHORT. NAME ONE OR TWO SPECIFIC THINGS YOU LOVE ABOUT THE CHILD. THANK THEM. RESPECT THEIR PRIVACY. THE BIRTH FAMILY IS GOING THROUGH SOMETHING ENORMOUS TOO.

WHO ELSE NEEDS COMMUNICATION ACCESS

The child, when they are old enough:

Extended birth family (grandparents, aunts/uncles, if they are in the picture):

How we will talk about our family

This page sets the language now, before the child can understand it, so the language is already natural by the time they are old enough.

LANGUAGE WE WANT TO USE

- ☐ "Our family is a family that began through adoption."
- ☐ "She is our daughter. She has a birth mother, who chose this family for her."
- ☐ "He has two mothers, his birth mother and me."
- ☐ "Our family came together when ..."
- ☐ Other:

LANGUAGE WE WANT TO AVOID (and why)

"REAL MOM / REAL DAD"

Why: implies the adoptive parent is not real. Both are real, in different ways. Use "birth mother" + "mom" / "adoptive parent" + "mom" depending on context.

"GAVE UP" or "GAVE AWAY"

Why: implies indifference. Adoption advocates and adult adoptees often prefer "made an adoption plan" or "placed for adoption" or simply "the choice they made."

"LUCKY" (about the child)

Why: implies the child should be grateful. Adoption is a loss for the child, even when it is also a gift. Use "loved" or "wanted" rather than "lucky."

"OUR OWN" (to distinguish biological from adopted children, if you have both)

Why: implies the adopted child is not "our own." If you have both, you have "two children." Full stop.

"CHOSEN" as the only frame

Why: while "we chose you" can be loving, it can also imply the child was selected like a product. Use sparingly and in context.

WHAT WE WILL TELL OUR CHILD, IN AGE-APPROPRIATE WAYS

At toddler age: simple, "our family came together through adoption, you grew in

another mom's belly, and we
became your family"

At school age: more detail, including the birth
family's situation as the child can
handle it

At teenage / adult: full information, including
anything we have shielded them
from earlier

WHAT WE WILL NOT SAY

- ☐ We will not present the adoption as a fairy tale
- ☐ We will not present the birth family negatively
- ☐ We will not require gratitude
- ☐ We will not tell strangers their full story (they get to decide who to tell, as they grow)

A NOTE: ADULT ADOPTEES HAVE WRITTEN EXTENSIVELY ABOUT THE LANGUAGE THEY WISH HAD BEEN USED IN THEIR CHILDHOODS. THEIR VOICES MATTER MORE THAN OUR INSTINCTS. SEEK OUT ADULT-ADOPTÉE-LED RESOURCES.

A final letter

You waited. You filed the paperwork. You wrote the essays. You answered the questions. You went through the inspections. You wired the funds. You took the calls. You held the disappointment of the times that did not become. You held the hope of the times that might.

A child is on the way to you, or has just arrived, or will arrive, on a timeline that you did not write.

Whatever the next year of your family looks like, you got here through a different door than most. That door is just as real. The family that walks through it is just as real.

The first year is hard for most adoptive families. The bonding is sometimes immediate and sometimes slow. The post-adoption depression is real (and yes, adoptive parents experience postpartum-style mood disorders, the research is clear on this. if you are not okay, the perinatal mental-health line applies to you too). The questions from strangers are constant. The birth-family relationship is its own ongoing thing.

You are doing it. The planner closes here. The family begins.

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*Made for the version of you no one tells you about, the
one at four in the morning, the one in the parking lot, the
one who doesn't recognize her own week.*

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